

ON THE LINE Sabarmati Express coaches derail near Kanpur after the engine hit an object on the track, Aug. 17

ANI

SABOTAGE SURGE

- **Rising sabotage incidents—56 this year—threaten India's vast railway network, endangering millions of daily passengers**
- **Motivations vary from social media fame to theft, with some cases involving railway staff themselves**
- **Railways is implementing increased surveillance and community engagement to combat the trend**

RAILWAYS

TROUBLE ON TRACKS

By Avishek G. Dastidar

On a September morning this year, between the quaint railway stations of Chikalthan and Karmad in Maharashtra, the locomotive of the Nandigram Express struck something solid on the track. As the driver slammed the emergency brakes, passengers were jolted awake, unaware of the close brush with disaster. Upon inspection, the railway staff discovered a concrete boulder and a cable marker block deliberately placed on the track. Though no passenger was harmed, the train's engine and several components of the track were damaged, and emergency crews worked through the night to clear the debris. This was no accident. In the records of Indian Railways, it was an act of sabotage.

This is part of a worrying trend visible across India's 132,000-kilometre railway network. Boulders, iron bars, gas cylinders, fire extinguishers, hammers and even bikes have been found in the way of running trains. Signalling equipment is vanishing in the middle of nowhere. The objects are large enough to derail a speeding train on impact, putting in danger the lives of over 24 million passengers who use the network daily. As such, the acts of sabotage are not new. But lately, say the ministry insiders, they have grown in number and in "creativity" shown by saboteurs—some 56 cases in 2024 so far, across India.

In one such case in Uttar Pradesh in August this year, a YouTuber, Ayaan Khan, placed a gas tank on the tracks near Prayagraj, recording it to gain fame for his channel. He was later arrested and charged under the Railway Act sections dealing with trespassing, unlawful interference with operations and endangering the safety of passengers. The Railways has alerted the National Investigation Agency (NIA), the premier counter-terrorism law enforcement agency, to probe any possible pattern behind the spike in such incidents. "The NIA is involved," confirms railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, "and we are also in touch with the state police to see to it that such miscreants are identified and such incidents are prevented." So when the Mysuru-Darbhanga Bagmati Express collided with a stationary goods train in Tamil Nadu on October 11, derail-